Before You Say Yes

Your first AE job interview kit

Ask better questions before accepting the offer.

START HERE

Read this before the interview

A practical interview kit for SDRs considering their first account executive role.

A bigger title. A bigger number. A lot you still need to find out.

An offer might say $180,000 OTE. That tells you what the company says you could earn at target. It does not tell you whether the territory, pipeline, training, and commission rules make that target realistic.

Use this kit to ask specific questions, compare answers, and decide which uncertainties you can live with. You cannot remove every risk. You can learn more before you say yes.

How to use it

Before the first call: use the examples on the next page to write your three nonnegotiables.

During interviews: choose the questions that fit the person and the time available. You do not need to ask all 19 at once.

After each conversation: record the answer, who gave it, and what still needs checking.

Before accepting: complete the offer comparison and decision pages. Ask for the current compensation plan and written offer.

Inside the kit

Nonnegotiables 03 / Recruiter questions 04-08 / Hiring manager questions 09-16 / Current rep questions 17-22 / Vague answers 23 / Evidence log 24 / Offer comparison 25 / Pay scenarios 26 / Decision 27

Type in the fields using a PDF reader that supports forms, then save a copy. You can also print the kit and write by hand.

How to read the flags

Every answer example is illustrative. A green flag gives you something concrete to verify; it is not a guarantee. A red flag is a reason to probe, especially when a pattern persists. "I do not know, but I will find out" is an incomplete answer, not automatically a red flag. Confirm the facts and judge them against your needs.

BEFORE THE FIRST CALL

Set your nonnegotiables

A nonnegotiable is a condition you would decline the offer over, even if everything else looked great.

These are examples, not requirements for everyone. Choose what matters to you and make it specific enough to check.

Written pay terms

"I will not accept until I have reviewed the written commission plan, including payout timing and clawbacks."

Base salary

"I need at least $80,000 in base salary. I will not rely on commission to cover essential bills." Adjust the amount to your needs.

Coaching

"For my first AE role, I need weekly call reviews with my manager during the first 90 days."

Work location

"I need a remote role. A position requiring three office days a week does not work for me."

Travel

"I am willing to travel up to two nights a month. More than that is a no for me."

Defined responsibilities

"Before accepting, I need to know my territory, customer segment, and whether I am responsible for sourcing my own pipeline."

Preference or nonnegotiable

"I would like a sign-on bonus" is a preference if you would still accept without it. Ask yourself: If they cannot meet this condition, will I actually decline?

My three nonnegotiables

How I will verify them before accepting

01 RECRUITER

Get the basics straight

Find out what the role actually is before investing in the rest of the process.

01 Why is this position open?

WHY THIS MATTERS

A new seat, a promotion backfill, and repeated turnover create different starting conditions. You want to know what happened before you inherit the territory and expectations.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Is it a new seat, a backfill, or a territory split? If it is a backfill, how long was the last person in the role?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"The last AE was promoted after 18 months. This is their existing territory. Your manager can explain the handover and remaining pipeline."

Why: The opening has a clear cause, and someone can explain what transfers. A backfill itself is not a problem.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"The last three people did not work out. We just need someone hungry enough."

Why: Repeated exits combined with no explanation of what changed can mean the next rep inherits the same obstacles.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

01 RECRUITER

Get the basics straight

Find out what the role actually is before investing in the rest of the process.

02 How is the advertised OTE split?

WHY THIS MATTERS

OTE means on-target earnings, not guaranteed pay. The split and ramp terms determine how much income is dependable while you learn and build pipeline.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

What are the base, target variable, ramp period, and any guaranteed ramp payments? Is a draw recoverable?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"It is $90,000 base and $90,000 target variable. The first three months include a nonrecoverable guarantee. We will send the amounts and dates."

Why: You can distinguish guaranteed pay from conditional earnings and check the terms before making a decision.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"It is $180,000 OTE. Do not worry about the split or draw details until you start."

Why: You cannot judge the income risk if the guaranteed portion and potential repayment obligations remain unclear.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

01 RECRUITER

Get the basics straight

Find out what the role actually is before investing in the rest of the process.

03 What would I own in this role?

WHY THIS MATTERS

The AE title can cover very different jobs. Owning renewals, finding every opportunity, and closing SDR-sourced deals require different skills and time commitments.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Which segment and geography? Is it new business, expansion, renewals, or a mix? Who prospects?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"You will sell new business to US firms with 100-500 employees. You prospect; one shared SDR supports the team. Renewals belong to customer success."

Why: The responsibilities and support are concrete enough to compare with your experience and preferred way of working.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"You own everything. We will work out the territory and support after you join."

Why: Important parts of the job are undefined. You could accept one role and end up doing another.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

01 RECRUITER

Get the basics straight

Find out what the role actually is before investing in the rest of the process.

04 What does the interview process involve?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Knowing the process lets you decide how much time to invest and whether assignments have clear boundaries. It also shows who actually makes the hiring decision.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

How many stages, who decides, and what preparation is expected? Is any assignment hypothetical?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"There are three stages: manager interview, hypothetical discovery exercise, then a rep conversation. The exercise takes about an hour. The manager decides."

Why: The time, purpose, and decision owner are clear. You can prepare without guessing what comes next.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"We do not know how many rounds. First, build an outreach plan for these live target accounts and contact them."

Why: An open-ended process involving real selling work can consume substantial effort without clear evaluation criteria or a hiring commitment.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

01 RECRUITER

Get the basics straight

Find out what the role actually is before investing in the rest of the process.

05 When can I review the compensation plan?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Your commission plan determines what counts, when you get paid, and what can be reversed. A headline OTE leaves most of those rules unanswered.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Before accepting, can I see quota, payout timing, accelerators, clawbacks, and how plan changes work?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"We will share the current plan before you accept and review examples of credit, payment timing, accelerators, and cancellations."

Why: You can inspect the actual rules and ask questions while you still have a choice.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"You have to accept first. The plan is standard, and finance can explain it after onboarding."

Why: You are being asked to commit before seeing a material part of the offer. A verbal summary does not resolve that gap.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

What does the recruiter need to confirm?

02 HIRING MANAGER

Can a new rep succeed here

Ask for comparable reps and recent periods. A star performer is one example.

01 Of fully ramped AEs on this team, how many hit quota?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Quota attainment puts advertised earnings in context. A percentage without a time period or a defined group can hide a very different picture of the team.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

For each of the last two completed quarters, how many hit out of how many? Were people who left included?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"In Q2, 6 of 10 fully ramped AEs hit quota; in Q3, 7 of 11 did. Here is how we counted departures and defined fully ramped."

Why: You can examine the actual population and trend. These example percentages are not universal benchmarks or proof the quota is reasonable.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"Everyone who works hard hits. We do not share numbers, but our best rep made $300,000."

Why: A top performer does not answer how typical reps perform. Replacing team data with a claim about effort prevents a useful comparison.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

02 HIRING MANAGER

Can a new rep succeed here

Ask for comparable reps and recent periods. A star performer is one example.

02 What happened to the last three first time AEs you hired?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Experienced closers may succeed with little support. You need evidence about people learning to run discovery, demos, negotiations, and deals for the first time.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

How long until their first deal and full quota? How are they doing now? If there were fewer than three, what examples do you have?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Two of our last three first-time AEs are at full quota after six months. One struggled and moved back to SDR. We added more discovery coaching."

Why: The manager includes a difficult outcome and explains what the team learned, rather than showing only the success story.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"We have never hired a first-time AE, but you should be fully productive in 30 days. There is no formal coaching."

Why: The company has no comparable evidence and little support for an ambitious ramp. Being the first is a risk to assess, not an automatic rejection.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

02 HIRING MANAGER

Can a new rep succeed here

Ask for comparable reps and recent periods. A star performer is one example.

03 What would my territory look like on day one?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Your starting territory affects what you can realistically build. A list of accounts or an impressive pipeline total is useful only if the accounts fit and the opportunities are real.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

How many accounts, how were they selected, and what existing pipeline would transfer? Can we review an anonymized example?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"You start with 180 named accounts. We can review the selection criteria and the five open opportunities, including age, stage, and next steps."

Why: You can inspect the starting conditions rather than treating every listed opportunity as likely revenue.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"You have a $2 million pipeline. Some deals are a year old, but we count everything until someone marks it lost."

Why: A large number can include stale opportunities. If quota assumes those deals will close, the starting position may be overstated.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

02 HIRING MANAGER

Can a new rep succeed here

Ask for comparable reps and recent periods. A star performer is one example.

04 Where did recent new hires get their opportunities?

WHY THIS MATTERS

The source of pipeline changes the daily job. An AE who must create nearly every opportunity needs time and skills that an inbound-heavy role may not require.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Roughly how much came from their own prospecting, SDRs, marketing, partners, or inherited deals?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Recent hires generated about 60% themselves. Marketing and SDRs supplied the rest. Here are examples from two recently ramped reps."

Why: You can plan for the actual prospecting workload. Self-sourced pipeline is not inherently a bad sign when expectations are clear.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"Marketing feeds the team," followed by no examples and a rep saying nearly every opportunity is self-sourced.

Why: The issue is the mismatch between the promised support and the work required. Clarify the discrepancy before relying on the promise.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

What do I need to verify about the starting conditions?

A natural way to introduce these questions

"This would be my first AE role, so I want to understand what the transition looks like here. Could we walk through a recent example?"

03 HIRING MANAGER

Understand the daily job

Look at the work, the coaching, and what happens when a deal gets difficult.

05 What does a typical won deal look like?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Deal size and sales cycle help you understand how many wins quota requires and how long revenue takes to arrive. One exceptional deal can distort the story.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

What are the median deal size and sales cycle for this segment? From which stage is the cycle measured?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"The median new-business deal in your segment was $24,000 last quarter. The median cycle was 75 days from qualified discovery to signature."

Why: The segment, period, and starting point are defined, so you can relate the numbers to your territory and ramp.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"Average deals are $100,000," but that includes one large enterprise win while this role sells to much smaller companies.

Why: An unrepresentative average can make the required number of wins look much easier than the actual role supports.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

03 HIRING MANAGER

Understand the daily job

Look at the work, the coaching, and what happens when a deal gets difficult.

06 What support would I get in my first 90 days?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Moving from SDR to AE means learning more than how to book a meeting. You need to know who helps you learn the parts of the job you have not done.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Who reviews my calls, joins early demos, and helps with pricing or procurement? How often?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Your manager reviews two calls each week. You shadow demos in month one, and an SE joins technical calls. Here is the 30/60/90-day plan."

Why: The people, activities, and cadence are specific enough to verify with a current rep.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"You will figure it out. The manager has no time for calls, but the training library is there."

Why: Resources alone may not give a first-time AE feedback on live deals. The support may fall short of what your transition requires.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

03 HIRING MANAGER

Understand the daily job

Look at the work, the coaching, and what happens when a deal gets difficult.

07 How do you coach someone who is behind?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most reps eventually fall behind. The response tells you whether the manager diagnoses the problem and helps, or only increases pressure after results slip.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Could you walk me through a recent example, without naming the rep? What changed and how much time did they have?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"One rep had enough meetings but weak discovery. We reviewed calls weekly, practiced that skill, and agreed on specific changes over six weeks."

Why: The manager connects a performance issue to observable behavior and a practical coaching plan.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"If you miss a month, we put you on a plan. Good reps do not need hand-holding."

Why: A performance plan is not automatically a warning sign. Immediate pressure without diagnosis or support leaves little room to develop.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

03 HIRING MANAGER

Understand the daily job

Look at the work, the coaching, and what happens when a deal gets difficult.

08 What most often stops deals from closing?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Lost deals reveal what you will have to navigate. Product limitations, procurement delays, competition, and rep skill gaps each require a different response.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Thinking about the last five losses, what happened? Where do new AEs tend to struggle?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Of our last five losses, two stalled in security review, two stayed with the incumbent, and one had no budget. Here is how we address each."

Why: The manager can name specific causes and discuss practical responses without pretending every problem is solved.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"The product always wins. We only lose when reps fail to create urgency."

Why: Blaming every loss on the seller can hide real product or market constraints and limit the help you get when deals stall.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

What support is specific and what is still a promise?

Close with one useful question

"Based on what you know about my experience, where do you think I would need the most help?" Ask how that help would actually work.

04 CURRENT REP

Hear what the job feels like

Ask to speak with a recently ramped AE. If possible, also speak with someone who moved from SDR to AE.

01 What surprised you after you joined?

WHY THIS MATTERS

A recent hire can describe the gap between the advertised job and the actual one. Surprises help you decide which tradeoffs you can live with.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

What did you expect to be easier than it turned out to be?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"There was more prospecting than I expected. I raised it with my manager, and we adjusted how I split my week."

Why: An imperfect experience can still show candor and a workable response. Ask whether the same expectation is now clear to new hires.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"The territory and office requirements changed in my first week. People are discouraged from mentioning it during interviews."

Why: Material surprises combined with pressure to conceal them undermine how much you can trust the recruiting conversation.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

04 CURRENT REP

Hear what the job feels like

Ask to speak with a recently ramped AE. If possible, also speak with someone who moved from SDR to AE.

02 How long did it take to close your first deal?

WHY THIS MATTERS

A fast first win may reflect inherited pipeline rather than a repeatable ramp. The source and stage of that first deal make the timing meaningful.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Where did it come from? Was it inherited or did you create it?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"My first win was in month three. It came from an SDR meeting after I joined. The manager helped with discovery and procurement."

Why: You can see the starting point and support behind the result. Three months is an example, not a target for every role.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"I closed in two weeks," but the deal was already in final procurement and the company presents that as a normal new-hire ramp.

Why: An inherited late-stage deal is not evidence that a new rep can repeatedly build and close business that quickly.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

04 CURRENT REP

Hear what the job feels like

Ask to speak with a recently ramped AE. If possible, also speak with someone who moved from SDR to AE.

03 Where did your last five opportunities come from?

WHY THIS MATTERS

A rep can show whether the promised lead support reaches the team. Recent opportunities are more useful than a general claim that marketing is strong.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

How much of a normal week do you spend finding pipeline?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Three of my last five came from my prospecting, one from an SDR, and one from a partner. I spend roughly two mornings a week creating pipeline."

Why: You get a concrete view of the work. Five deals are a small sample, so ask whether that mix is typical.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"All five were self-sourced. The inbound leads usually go to two senior reps," when you were told new hires get equal inbound support.

Why: Unequal allocation may be a deliberate policy, but it changes your opportunity. The recruiting promise needs correcting.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

04 CURRENT REP

Hear what the job feels like

Ask to speak with a recently ramped AE. If possible, also speak with someone who moved from SDR to AE.

04 What happens when you need help on a deal?

WHY THIS MATTERS

Access to help matters most when a live deal needs a quick decision or expertise you do not yet have. Ask what happened recently, not whether the culture is supportive.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Can you give me a recent example of your manager helping?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Last week my manager joined a pricing call, and an SE helped with a security questionnaire. I knew how to get both involved."

Why: Support has a clear route and a recent example. Check whether new hires get similar access.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"I waited two weeks for discount approval and lost the deal. There is no escalation path, and this keeps happening."

Why: Repeated internal delays can hurt performance even when a rep does good work. Find out what has changed.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

04 CURRENT REP

Hear what the job feels like

Ask to speak with a recently ramped AE. If possible, also speak with someone who moved from SDR to AE.

05 How clear are the commission statements?

WHY THIS MATTERS

A clear plan is only useful if you can follow the actual payouts. You want to know whether errors are visible and whether there is a reliable way to resolve them.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

Can you reconcile payouts to your deals? Have there been surprises with credit, timing, or reversals?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Each statement lists the deal, credit, rate, and payment. One error took a pay cycle to fix, and finance explained the adjustment."

Why: An occasional corrected error can happen. Transparency and a dependable correction process make the system easier to trust.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"Statements are just one total. Several of us have unresolved differences from months ago, and no one will walk through them."

Why: Persistent unexplained discrepancies make it hard to verify pay or predict cash flow. Ask for the review process and resolution history.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

04 CURRENT REP

Hear what the job feels like

Ask to speak with a recently ramped AE. If possible, also speak with someone who moved from SDR to AE.

06 Who tends to do well here and who struggles?

WHY THIS MATTERS

A role can be a good job and still be a poor fit for you. Find out which conditions, habits, and working styles tend to succeed in this specific team.

ASK ONE LEVEL DEEPER

What would you want to know if you were joining again?

GREEN FLAG ANSWER

"Reps comfortable building their own pipeline do well. People expecting lots of inbound struggle. It suits me, but I wish I had known that earlier."

Why: The rep describes a concrete fit condition you can compare with your strengths and preferences.

RED FLAG ANSWER

"People who take time off get called out. Nobody uses the advertised vacation policy because they fear losing accounts."

Why: A gap between stated benefits and how people are treated can affect your day-to-day life. Verify the pattern and decide whether it violates a nonnegotiable.

WHAT I HEARD AND WHAT TO VERIFY

What matched the manager account and what differed?

05 WHEN ANSWERS GET VAGUE

Ask without making it awkward

You are trying to understand the job. Keep your tone curious and give people room to check.

"Our top reps make $300,000."

"Good to know. What did the middle fully ramped rep earn last year? An anonymized range is fine."

If earnings cannot be shared, ask for the attainment distribution and the written payout rules.

"Most people hit quota."

"When you say most, about how many out of how many, and over which period?"

Then ask how new hires and departures were counted.

"There is plenty of pipeline."

"What would actually transfer to me? How much is already qualified, and how old is it?"

Ask what their qualification standard requires and whether opportunities have confirmed next steps.

"The territory has huge potential."

"Could we look at what makes it promising? How many accounts match the customer profile, and what has sold there recently?"

If the territory is untested, record that as an uncertainty rather than assuming proven demand.

"The plan is pretty standard."

"Could you send the current plan and walk me through a deal below quota, at quota, and above quota?"

If it is not available yet, ask who can provide it and when.

When two answers conflict

"I may be mixing up two different groups. I heard 70% from the recruiter and 40% from the team. Are those different periods or different definitions?"

An incomplete answer is something to follow up on. Repeated refusal to clarify a material condition is information for your decision.

06 EVIDENCE LOG

Separate answers from assumptions

Reuse this page for each offer. Save another copy if you need more room.

Company and role

The claim or answer that matters

Who said it and when?

What supports it? Record the period, population, example, or document.

What is missing or inconsistent?

My exact follow up question and who can answer it

When will I follow up and what would settle the question?

Worked example

Claim: "70% hit quota." Basis: recruiter, no period given. Missing: fully ramped only? People who left? Follow up: "For Q2 and Q3, how many fully ramped AEs on this team hit quota out of how many?" Status: unverified until clarified.

07 COMPARE TWO OFFERS

Put the offers side by side

Use confirmed facts. Write unknown when you do not have an answer. More OTE does not automatically mean more attainable pay.

	OFFER A	OFFER B
Company and role		
Base / target variable / OTE		
Ramp quota / guaranteed pay / recoverable draw		
Team attainment with period and denominator		
Starting accounts and qualified pipeline		
Prospecting expectations and support		
Manager coaching and first 90 days		
Payout timing / accelerators / caps / clawbacks		
Travel / office days / workload / nonnegotiables		
Biggest remaining unknown		

Do not total these rows into a fit score. One unacceptable condition can outweigh several attractive ones.

08 UNDERSTAND THE MONEY

Work through three pay scenarios

Ask the company to calculate these using its written plan. These are planning scenarios, not earnings forecasts.

A simple hypothetical example

Base: $90,000. Target variable: $90,000. Annual quota: $900,000 in credited revenue. A flat 10% commission rate applies up to quota; 15% applies only to credited revenue above quota. Assume full-year employment, no ramp, no caps, no splits, and no reversals.

At 50% attainment: $450,000 x 10% = $45,000 commission. Base plus commission = $135,000.

At 100% attainment: $900,000 x 10% = $90,000 commission. Base plus commission = $180,000.

At 125% attainment: $90,000 + ($225,000 x 15%) = $123,750 commission. Base plus commission = $213,750.

Your plan may use different rules. Ask what earns credit, whether rates apply marginally or retroactively, when accelerators reset, and whether customer payment affects payout. Model the ramp period separately.

My offer at 50% attainment and assumptions

My offer at 100% attainment and assumptions

My offer at 125% attainment and assumptions

My guaranteed ramp pay and any amount I could owe back

Also confirm in writing

How splits, cancellations, clawbacks, plan changes, and leaving the company affect earned or unpaid commissions. Ask for worked examples where the wording is unclear.

09 MAKE THE DECISION

What would make this a yes

Decide what you need to know, which risks you accept, and which conditions do not work for you.

Company and role / decision deadline

The strongest evidence this could work for me

The biggest risk and what would make it manageable

What I still need to verify before accepting

The tradeoff I am willing to accept and the one I am not

My decision and why / accept, decline, or clarify first

A message you can use

"Thanks for the offer. Before I make a decision, I want to clarify [specific point]. Could you share [document or example] by [date]? That would help me understand what I would be agreeing to."

One last check

Can you explain how you would build pipeline, get coached, reach quota, and get paid? If an important part of that story is still a guess, name it before you decide.